Name

Christy Splitt

Address

[redacted]

How long have you lived at your current address?

9 years

Phone Number

[redacted]

Email Address

[redacted]

How would you prefer to be contacted?

Email

1. What motivated you to apply for a position on the school board? Please include any experiences you have had with the school district as a parent, student, educator, or community member, nonprofit or public board.

I am motivated to apply for this position because I want to be in the best possible place to support Portland's public schools, all of the people who spend their days there, and the families that comprise the PPS community. In a school board role, I can do that in partnership with the board and district. I can also be a strong ambassador in various external conversations, such as within the Oregon School Boards Association and with the Legislature.

My experiences with the school district go back to 2004, when I was briefly a PPS substitute teacher. I spent time in middle school classrooms at what was then Binnsmead and at Winterhaven, and saw firsthand the inequities within the district. Later, I was a unit coach for Lincoln High School's constitution team for 12 years, offering a chance to see one of the brightest stars in PPS up close.

For the past five years, I have been a PPS parent. My children are now in 1st and 4th grades at Hayhurst Elementary, where I have been a weekly K-5 lunch volunteer since 2021. I also served as PTA president

for two years and now serve as PTA treasurer. Our school roughly matches the demographics of the district - we have about 30% underserved students, including two district special education classrooms.

2. What is your understanding of the primary functions and responsibilities of a public school board?

The school board is tasked with evaluating and approving the annual budget and district policies. The board hires and evaluates the superintendent's work based on goals adopted by the board. The board also approves contracts with our union workforce.

In addition, board members serve as ambassadors between the district and the schools, students, and families in their zone, as well as ambassadors for the district in external settings. For instance, I consider it a board member's responsibility to reach out to school and other communities in support of the bond ahead of the May election. I'd expect to hear from and respond to residents in my district about their concerns and hopes for our schools. I also consider it a board member's responsibility to engage in legislative sessions and with legislators and elected officials representing their zones, to deepen relationships between PPS and other districts, and find chances to advance public schools in other arenas.

3. How would you prioritize issues such as academic achievement, equity, student mental health, and teacher support? Can you give an example of a time you took action or provided leadership to prioritize an issue of importance.

All of these issues matter deeply. We should not have to choose.

My answer stems from the first days of my Masters in Education coursework. Many observers focus on test scores - one measure of academic progress. But, anyone who has spent time in a school knows that you can't expect a kid who has unmet needs to excel. Equity cannot be achieved without providing support to kids in need, so I'd put equity first.
Student mental health and teacher support come next. Kids need to feel safe and they need to feel a sense of belonging in order to learn. And it's hard to foster a school environment in which kids' foundational needs are met without reasonable workloads and time to learn and prepare for educators.

I believe that as equity, mental health, and teacher support are addressed, academic achievement will improve.

For the last three years, I have driven advocacy for essential positions - our assistant principal and art teacher - that improve safety, increase belonging, and address equity in our school. I contacted district staff, created tools to help others take action, and testified to the school board - to nodding heads and snaps. While foundation funding had to be used last year for our art teacher, the assistant principal position has been district-funded every year.

4. How do you envision supporting students from diverse backgrounds and ensuring educational equity?

As mentioned, I believe that equity starts with addressing basic needs for all students. From my time observing one school very closely, I see that every adult in the school plays a critical role in this effort. Our kitchen team may notice that a student is not getting enough food at home. The recess aide may catch that a student is exhausted because their home has no heat. Our social worker can take that information and help those kids and families get what they need. Teachers and administrators can use anti-bias and anti-racist training to improve their response to behavior issues and help kids feel safe at school. Teachers can use curriculum that shows kids of all backgrounds having all sorts of experiences, helping to increase a sense of belonging.

As a school board member, I'd take this general approach into board decisions - that addressing student readiness to learn must come first. I'd listen carefully to kids and families that experience injustice - racial, social, economic - in making decisions. I also know the political reality that test scores - as the easiest to assess measure of academic progress - matter deeply to district observers. I'd seek ways to help the community understand that increased investment in equity measures will, in fact, improve test scores.

5. What particular skills or expertise would you bring to the Board?

For the past 20 years, I have worked in or near Oregon's legislature. I have been a legislative staffer, a grassroots advocate and coalition leader, a nonprofit fundraiser, and a state agency government relations coordinator. I know the role of an elected official, and I know the role of staff. I understand budgets. I am aware of how committees and boards function, and the role of external organizations and the public in these processes.

This work has also taught me many skills that I could bring to the Board. For example, I am very interested in the evolution of the Fund for Portland Public Schools and could bring my fundraising experience to that conversation. I am also adept at building consensus, whether within a coalition or among partisan legislators.

Earlier in my career, I was a high school social studies teacher. My PPS volunteer work has kept that experience fresh in my mind. My “teacher voice” remains strong - I easily communicate with students - and my interest in learning from kids and centering their needs has never wavered.

Combining all of these roles, skills, and experiences, I have a passion for connecting people to their government. Every government body has work to do when it comes to genuinely engaging the public in meaningful and equitable ways.

6. How would you balance the needs of students, teachers, and the broader community when making decisions?

Students come first. Always. I happen to think that often what is best for teachers (and support staff) is good for kids, so I don’t think of the two as mutually exclusive. I consider parents and caregivers critical partners in education, and I’d also be thoughtful about their needs. Beyond these groups are voters and taxpayers, community based organizations, the media, other community decision-makers, and the business community. I’d be interested to hear from these groups, but I consider their needs to be less urgent than the needs of kids, school staff, and families.

For the most part, I question the idea that these groups have needs that are in conflict. In Portland, I often hear of broad agreement between school staff and families. However, as we face continued budget cuts in our district, this dynamic may change. My approach to finding balance in times of conflict would start with an open mind and careful listening and prioritize what’s best for the kids who need the most support.

7. How do you think about the trade-offs in the school district’s budgeting process?

I consider it my life’s work to improve school funding in Oregon so that we can move on from the last 30 years of underinvestment. I can’t help but start this answer there. It’s a shame that our board and PPS staff have had to put forward and adopt budgets that everyone knows are inadequate and with

trade-offs that no one supports. I'd be a steadfast and vocal advocate for bringing more resources to PPS, full stop.

Our district budget is dense, even for the most engaged community members. I'd want to really dig in on where dollars go so that I'd be able to properly consider tradeoffs. I know I'd continue to focus on positions at schools as the first priority. Until kids' basic needs are met and they feel safe and welcome at school (which I think is in jeopardy with further cuts in schools), nice-to-haves have to wait.

8.What experience do you have advocating for a cause, issue, campaign, legislation, etc.?

As mentioned, my career has been in advocacy. I have worked to secure passage of legislation across many issues and inclusion of budget items across many programs. In some cases, I have done this work quietly and mostly alone - like in passing "fix it" bills for a state agency. In some cases, the work has involved large coalitions, extensive grassroots organizing, and deep engagement with decision-makers.

An example of this was being part of efforts to pass climate-related bills between 2007 and 2024, which I worked on from multiple perspectives over time:

2007-2011 - Legislative Assistant to Portland Legislator Ben Cannon
2012 - Legislative Director to Co-Speaker Arnie Roblan
2013-2016 - Director, Oregon Conservation Network
2020-2024 - Government Relations Coordinator, Oregon Department of Energy

Recently, I have advocated for a cause outside of work: school funding. Since 2023, I have helped organize parents and caregivers to engage with the Legislature. This started with recruiting parents to testify at the State School Fund hearing in 2023, then more recently a lobby day, two town hall events, and an advocacy training preparing for the upcoming session. Along with other leaders, I have also helped encourage individual school communities to engage their legislators.

9. What does diversity, equity, and inclusion mean to you in the context of public education? What is your lived experience that defines this perspective?

These terms are defined in many places, by many scholars, and even by the district. These are my own definitions, offered with humility.

Diversity in public education means that people from different racial, cultural, social, financial, and other backgrounds work and learn together. Differences are valued and explored rather than ignored or minimized.

Equity in public education means that everything possible is done to bring each kid to the same starting line. That means more time or resources go toward kids who need the most support - not that every kid gets the same.

Inclusion means that everyone - regardless of race, color, ethnicity, nationality, immigration status, different ability, gender, sexual orientation - feels a sense of belonging at school. In the most inclusive school, all kids and all staff feel pride and ownership for their school community.

As a straight white woman, I benefit from white privilege. As a child, I did not think about my own race or class or immigration status. However, that changed in college, when I started to be exposed to - and benefit from - more diversity. Since then, I have actively learned about the experiences of people of color and other marginalized groups and aim to not only include but center their voices in my work.

10. How would you work to address disparities in educational opportunities and outcomes for marginalized groups, including students of color, LGBTQ+ students, and students with disabilities?

One of the reasons that I want to be on the school board is that the board and the staff at PPS are deeply committed to addressing disparities. There's acknowledgement of historic and current racism in our city and in our schools. The district includes many people of color in leadership positions. There are goals in place to improve opportunities and outcomes for all, with a focus on Black and Native American kids who evidence shows need the most support. I'd gladly adopt the district's equity framework for my own decision-making as a board member.

Getting results will take time. It will also take investment. Addressing disparities without adequate funding is difficult if not impossible. I'd use my voice as a board member to urge additional investment in those kids and schools that need more support. Cuts to special education staffing were especially tough last year and that'd be an area I'd prioritize if there was additional funding provided by the Legislature.

I’m deeply concerned that the federal government may attempt to persuade school districts to drop policies that protect LGBTQ+ students and foster inclusivity, and I’d stand against any such measures. All kids should feel welcome at school, and all schools should stand against bullying and discrimination.